

SESSION 1 - CORE CONCEPTS OF COMMUNICATION

Diagnose where meaning breaks before trying to fix the wording.

CASE ANSWER FORMULA

Diagnose -> Name framework -> Apply case evidence -> Explain effect -> Recommend action

Core process

Source -> Encoding -> Message via Channel -> Decoding -> Receiver, with **feedback**, **noise**, **context** and the cultures of sender/receiver shaping **shared meaning**. Shared meaning comes in degrees.

8 reasons communication fails

1 Inadequate information; 2 Information overload; 3 Poor-quality information; 4 Poor timing; 5 Lack of feedback/follow-up; 6 Problems with channels; 7 Incompetent communication; 8 Ineffective goal-setting. Communication anxiety and cultural barriers can cut across all eight.

Context: the hidden half

Wider context = culture + organisational climate. **Individual context** = relationship + timing + history. Ask: Is there a message? How should it be read? What do the words literally say? The sender cannot control decoding, but can send more context.

Four organisational lenses

Classical: structure, rules, authority (Taylor/Weber). **Humanistic**: needs, motivation, participation; McGregor Theory X vs Y. **Systems**: interdependence, synergy, external environment. **Culture**: values, rites/rituals, heroes, norms, stories/myths, climate.

Case-use trigger

If a case says "the email was clear, but people still interpreted it differently," diagnose **context/decoding/shared meaning**. If the question asks why an organisation communicates the way it does, apply the **four lenses**.

Exam move

Write: **Symptom -> broken stage / failure type -> context -> consequence -> repair**. Repair by saying why, naming the reading you do not want, and asking "What will you do first?" rather than "Is that clear?"

HOW TO USE THIS SESSION IN A SITUATIONAL QUESTION

Do not dump frameworks. Pick the one that explains the evidence. Quote/paraphrase the case fact, connect it to the framework, then state a concrete communication intervention. For Session 1, use the bold terms above as your framework vocabulary.

SESSION 2 - STRATEGIC COMMUNICATION

Strategy is not only a plan; communication must create workable acceptance across stakeholders.

CASE ANSWER FORMULA

Diagnose -> Name framework -> Apply case evidence -> Explain effect -> Recommend action

Chaffee: 3 models of strategy

Linear: goals, alternatives, decision; communication presents the plan and seeks acceptance. **Adaptive:** continuous adjustment with the environment through feedback. **Interpretive:** strategy is socially constructed meaning negotiated among stakeholders.

Strategic communication realities

The audience is plural: employees, customers, owners, regulators, media, communities, interest groups. The source is rarely one person. Communication is a **transaction**: a source may secure compliance, but acceptance is granted by the receiver.

Miller (1997): conditions for strategic change

Backing - authorisers support it; **Accessibility** - managers understand the goal; **Specificity** - enough detail to act; **Cultural receptivity** - affected people will facilitate it; **Propitiousness** - favourable circumstances/luck.

Barrett (2002): effective employee communication

Management involved; integrated with strategy; consistent but targeted; face-to-face privileged while using all media; formally assessed.

Benoit (1995): repair strategies

When blamed: **Deny**; **Evade** responsibility; **Reduce offensiveness**; **Corrective action**; **Apologize**. They are not ranked - fit depends on what the audience already believes.

Case-use trigger

For failed change communication: identify which Miller/Barrett condition is absent. For reputational damage: label each clause using Benoit, then test it through the **interpretive lens** (who makes meaning?) and **critical lens** (whose interests does the framing serve?).

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SESSION 3 - VERBAL COMMUNICATION: THINKING + STRUCTURING

Clear wording cannot rescue weak reasoning; think first, then impose audience-sensitive order.

CASE ANSWER FORMULA

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Bell & Smith planning sequence

Purpose -> Audience -> Exploration -> Patterns/Outlines -> Details/Examples. Purpose asks what the audience should **know, feel, do**. Generate ideas before arguing for/against them.

Munter: thinking

1 Test/state assumptions. 2 Draw valid conclusions: **deduction** = general -> specific; **induction** = observations -> likely generalisation. 3 Avoid defects: too little evidence, false connection, either/or thinking, circular reasoning.

Managerial message architecture

Communication objective -> Main message -> Supporting information -> Desired action. The order you discovered information is irrelevant; the final order should serve the audience.

Idea hierarchy test

Higher level summarises below; same-level items are the same kind; keep roughly **5-7 branches**. Otherwise the message reads like a list rather than an argument.

Placement + structure

Audience memory is strongest at beginning/end, weakest in the middle. **Point-first:** recommendation -> strongest reason -> support, when audience wants a clear solution. **Build-up:** shared concern/value -> rejected alternative -> recommendation + reason, when resistance/context is high.

Argument test

Use **Claim -> Reason(s) -> Evidence**. In a case answer, explicitly separate **fact vs assumption**, expose the logic, then choose point-first or build-up based on audience receptivity.

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SESSION 4 - NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

The channel you cannot switch off: cue + expectation creates inference.

CASE ANSWER FORMULA

Diagnose -> Name framework -> Apply case evidence -> Explain effect -> Recommend action

Mechanism

Cue: observable wordless behaviour. **Expectation:** receiver's idea of what is normal. **Inference:** meaning assigned. Intention is yours; inference is theirs.

8 channels

Kinesics posture/gesture; **Oculesics** gaze; **Haptics** touch; **Proxemics** distance/territory; **Chronemics** time; **Vocalics** pitch/pace/volume/pause; **Artefacts** dress/objects/screens; **Environment** room/layout/lighting.

Kinesics: 5 gesture types

Emblems have stand-alone meaning; **Illustrators** depict words; **Affect displays** leak emotion; **Regulators** manage conversational traffic; **Adaptors** are self-soothing under pressure.

6 functions relative to speech

Repeat, Substitute, Complement, Accent, Contradict, Regulate. When channels conflict, receivers tend to believe the non-verbal cue. Do not misuse the "93% non-verbal" claim; the cited study concerned attitude under conflicting cues.

Baseline + culture warning

A "tell" matters only as a **departure from that person's baseline**. Read clusters, not one cue. Eye contact, punctuality, touch and distance vary across cultures; there is no universal codebook.

Design a managerial encounter

Plan four levers: **Space, Time, Artefacts, Body & Voice**. In a situational answer, name the intended inference and show how each lever supports it; also name the single cue that could contradict and wreck the message.

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SESSION 5 - LISTENING

Hearing is automatic; listening is effortful perception of meaning.

CASE ANSWER FORMULA

Diagnose -> Name framework -> Apply case evidence -> Explain effect -> Recommend action

Steil's LAW

Listening = Ability + Willingness. Ability is trainable (paraphrasing, questioning, organising, note-taking). Willingness is a choice often spent early through stereotyping, defensiveness or preferring to talk.

Five pitfalls of poor listening

Haste (willingness); **Defensiveness** (willingness); **Invisibility** (ability); **Exhaustion** (ability); **Inaction** (willingness). Diagnose before prescribing a technique.

Information bubble

Senior leaders have more channels but often receive the most filtered information: warnings softened, facts omitted, data positively spun. Personal listening therefore needs organisational systems that carry bad news upward.

Paraphrasing

Repetition returns words; **paraphrase returns meaning + emotional tone and invites correction.** Example logic: "So your concern is X, and Y is only the trigger - have I got that?"

Three axes of questioning

Open <-> Closed; Primary <-> Secondary; Neutral <-> Directed. Open retrieves information; closed focuses/commits. Secondary probes deeper. Directed usually retrieves confirmation, not new information.

Leadership listening matrix

Combine **individual listening skill** with **organisational systems**. Failures: bureaucratic system (process, no presence), performative listener (signals, no action), private listener (good one-to-one, invisible follow-through). Aim for **systemic + visible**.

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SESSION 6 - FEEDBACK

Feedback works only when giver and receiver both manage the conversation.

CASE ANSWER FORMULA

Diagnose -> Name framework -> Apply case evidence -> Explain effect -> Recommend action

Before giving feedback

Managers' own anxiety can distort the message. Three conditions help feedback land: **Relevant** (performance that matters), **No surprises** (regular informal check-ins), **Engaged** (full presence in delivery).

Do not default to the sandwich

Positive -> criticism -> positive can blur the critique. Two sharper options: **Ask-Tell-Ask** = self-assessment -> observed behaviour vs expectation -> improvement plan. **Bridge** = connect past, present and future expectations.

Feedforward

Future-focused suggestions rather than only reviewing the unchangeable past. Easier to give/receive, less defensive, task-focused, and does not assume giver superiority. It is an alternative/default in many everyday situations, not a total replacement for feedback.

Fear of feedback: maladaptive responses

Procrastination, Denial, Brooding, Jealousy, Self-sabotage. Silence invites worst-case assumptions and can damage performance before a formal review occurs.

Reframe the receiver's emotion

Anxiety -> "finding out opens options"; confrontation fear -> "taking initiative puts me in charge"; defensiveness -> "defending blocks what matters"; fear of change -> "one step at a time."

Exam sequence

As giver: **manage anxiety -> choose relevant evidence -> Ask-Tell-Ask/Bridge -> future action.** As receiver: **name emotion -> self-assess -> ask -> absorb -> act.**

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SESSION 7 - COMMUNICATING WITH TEAMS

Team communication is not volume of talk; it is shared, usable information that becomes coordinated action.

CASE ANSWER FORMULA

Diagnose -> Name framework -> Apply case evidence -> Explain effect -> Recommend action

Core diagnosis

A team cannot combine knowledge it does not know exists. Look for **information sharing**, **shared understanding**, **coordination**, **handoffs** and **boundary spanning** - not just who spoke most.

Closed-loop communication

For high-reliability coordination: **call out** -> **check back** -> **close the loop**. The sender states; receiver confirms understanding/action; sender verifies/corrects. Useful when ambiguity or handoff risk is costly.

Psychological safety / hierarchy

When people fear correction or challenge, teams lose warnings and unique knowledge. "Allowing" people to speak is insufficient if hierarchy still makes speaking costly.

Conformity risks

Conformity can coordinate; **polarization** pushes groups toward more extreme positions; **groupthink** suppresses realistic appraisal and dissent. Diagnose conditions and symptoms rather than labelling any agreement as groupthink.

Structured dissent

Advocacy makes a real case; **Devil's advocacy** attacks assumptions; **Dialectical inquiry** develops and tests competing positions. Build disagreement into the process rather than hoping someone volunteers it.

Manager takeaway

After a meeting ask: **What did people need to know, and how do I know they know it?** Also inspect incentives: if hoarding information pays, people will hoard it. Fix the system, not only the individual.

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SESSION 8 - DIFFICULT COMMUNICATION

Avoidance is itself a message; delayed truth usually compounds the eventual conversation.

CASE ANSWER FORMULA

Diagnose -> Name framework -> Apply case evidence -> Explain effect -> Recommend action

Stone's three conversations

1 What happened? Competing stories, evidence, contribution. **2 Feelings:** emotions and impact that are present but unspoken. **3 Identity:** threatened self-image, fear, what each person must accept to stay grounded. Both parties have all three.

Diagnose beneath the stated issue

The issue people open with may not be the real issue. Map: **stated issue -> each story -> feelings -> identity threat -> contribution -> desired outcome**. Avoid certainty about motives.

Direct vs indirect

Direct when the receiver/organisation expects directness or clarity must dominate. **Indirect** when relationship, resistance or face requires preparation. This is a strategic audience choice, not a universal rule.

Ethical indirectness

Indirect does **not** mean evasive. It is ethical when it prepares the receiver for the truth; it becomes unethical when it replaces the truth. A sugar-coated message can still do damage.

Negative-message design

Use an audience-appropriate opening/buffer, give clear reasons/context, state the bad news with sufficient clarity, then close with next steps/relationship where appropriate. The course explicitly contrasts "imply" with Stone's insistence on clarity depending on channel/context.

Exam move

For a conflict case: **diagnose all 3 Stone conversations -> choose direct/indirect -> draft the first 60 seconds -> preserve truth + dignity -> specify next action**.

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SESSION 9 - PERSUASIVE COMMUNICATION

Persuasion is give-and-take: listen, test, adapt, compromise, return.

CASE ANSWER FORMULA

Diagnose -> Name framework -> Apply case evidence -> Explain effect -> Recommend action

Conger: persuasion is not hard sell

Do not simply state a position and push. Persuasion is a process that can unfold over time; the formal meeting is only one part. Common failure: the "John Wayne" approach - strong position first, then pressure.

Conger's practical logic

Build **credibility**, find **common ground**, provide **vivid evidence**, and create **emotional connection**; remain flexible enough to absorb concerns. Treating flexibility as surrender makes agreement harder.

Sussman framing - 4 steps

1 **Specific behavioural objective**. 2 **SWOT the other party** - their position, not yours. 3 Identify **their core values**. 4 Write a short, simple, vivid, evaluative **frame** linking objective + their reality + values. Test whether it triggers thought rather than instant dismissal and is memorable.

Emotional match

Match the emotion already in the room rather than projecting your own. Evidence or imagery that clashes with the audience's current emotional state can read as manipulation or scare tactics.

Cialdini principles in organisations

Use the course's Cialdini principles as influence mechanisms, but connect each to actual case evidence rather than name-dropping. Ask what social/relational cue makes the proposed action easier to accept.

Head - Heart - Hands

Head: logic/evidence. **Heart**: values/emotion/identity. **Hands**: concrete action. In an exam pitch, align all three around the audience's problem - not the persuader's internal problem.

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SESSION 10 - CROSS-CULTURAL COMMUNICATION

Know the audience, then choose the frame; culture changes who the audience is and how the message is read.

CASE ANSWER FORMULA

Diagnose -> Name framework -> Apply case evidence -> Explain effect -> Recommend action

Hall: high vs low context

High-context communication relies more on relationship, shared understanding and implicit cues; **low-context** relies more on explicit, specific wording. Treat this as a relative continuum, not a stereotype.

Channel fit

With a high-context counterpart, an oral/relationship-first confirmation may fit better; a formal written move can imply distrust. With a low-context counterpart, writing often provides the expected specificity and protection. The Ford-Ferrari example illustrates channel mismatch.

Structure + direction

Direct cultures tend to state the conclusion first; indirect cultures build toward it. Direction matters: in more authoritarian settings, communication may become more direct downward and more indirect upward. Format conventions also vary.

Language can break in four ways

The session highlights multiple ways language fails even when everyone uses English, including **semantics** and culture-specific concepts without exact equivalents. Avoid assuming fluency equals identical meaning.

Global English

Prefer plain, literal, internationally accessible wording: reduce idioms, phrasal verbs, jargon and culturally specific shorthand. Example principle: replace business idiom with simple action language.

Framework discipline

The course ends with a menu of cultural frameworks/lenses, including Hall and other comparative models. **Select only 3-5 frameworks for which the case gives evidence**; do not force every cultural framework onto every case. State observations first, then interpretation, then recommendation.

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